

technology CCTV

The closed circuit TV camera is taking on the role of silent policing but an unregulated market and lack of awareness hinder its actual impact

■ **By Sandeep Unnithan and Mihir Srivastava**

A fzal Guru is asleep. The country's most famous convict, who insists only L.K. Advani can give him deliverance, lies in the suspended animation of an afternoon siesta. Books lie scattered around the white-tiled floor of a well-ventilated cell and sunlight streams in. Guru forms only one of six notebook-sized frames in a 29-inch LCD TV, one of 14 such screens on the wall of a swank control room being impassively scanned by a bespectacled B.K. Gupta, Director General (Prisons).

Until last year, the massive Tihar Jail complex in Delhi—nine separate prisons housing 11,000 inmates—was rife with complaints of bad food, shabby treatment from jail staff and sodomy among inmates. Clearly, a difficult task for just 1,300 jail staff to keep a vigil. All this changed around four months ago, when nearly 258 CCTV cameras went up in critical locations like high-security cells, entrances, kitchens, general barracks and halls housing a large number of prisoners. With 200 more cameras on the way, Asia's largest prison is now Big Brother country. Gupta even sounds Orwellian: "The prisoners know they are being watched, the staff knows that their actions are being monitored. There is no room for ambiguity."

Welcome to the surveillance society in which jails, temples, mosques, malls, markets and schools are policed by silent sentries. With CCTV footage admissible as evidence, "show me the footage" is fast becoming a buzzword for the police to confront and convict criminals. "CCTV footage helps in deducing useful information regarding the scene of crime, identification of accused and reconstruction of the sequence of crime," says Delhi Police spokesperson ACP Rajan Bhagat.

Every crime, it seems, now has a CCTV rewind moment. Two retired college professors—a husband-and-



wife duo—were caught on camera lifting jewellery from an exhibition at Pragati Maidan in Delhi. A thief cleaned out jewellery worth Rs 15 lakh from a shop in Karol Bagh and then made a ransom call asking for Rs 5 lakh to return the gems. His associate had disconnected the CCTV camera in the shop, however, it captured an image of the thief leading the police to him. The Mumbai Police were not as lucky when they trooped into Hypercity mall. The CCTVs had erased (after storing for two

days) what would have been model-actor Maria Sushairaj's greatest screen performance—shopping for bags and a large kitchen knife to chop up Neeraj Grover's corpse into pieces.

In North America and Europe, which make up over 65 per cent of the global CCTV market, the cameras are de rigueur. They're used to monitor traffic flows and deter public offences and act as valuable crime-fighting tools. British police presented CCTV footage as key evidence to pin the 2003 rape and

CCTVs act as crucial evidence in identifying criminals during investigations even days after the crime.